attempts to sabotage government programs. The press was to strongly back the “Burmese Way to Socialism.” In many ways, Ne Win's Burma resembled the communist states of Eastern Europe in how the media was controlled and manipulated.

STUDENT PROTEST AND GOVERNMENT RESPONSE

The main target of the Revolutionary Council would be the well-organized student movement in Burma. The universities were the hotbed of activity against the state, as well as the place where future political leaders would emerge. Any opposition to the state would lead to the closing of the school system from a few days up to several months. This could, of course, have severe repercussions for the economic development of Burma as well as the morale of the citizens. University councils were disbanded because of excessive foreign influence in educational policy and administration.

The military would take control over the universities in both Rangoon and Mandalay. After curfews were set by the military and hostels were closed, student activists took action. The Rangoon University Student Union, staged protests and took control over the student union. By the next morning, the military asserted control and blew up the union building. The building was historically significant because Aung San and the Thirty Comrades had organized themselves at that location back in the 1930s. The university would remain closed for the next four months.

Many historians believe any chance of Ne Win acquiring popular support for the regime was fatally damaged by blowing up this symbol of the anticolonial struggle that was closely associated with the national hero Aung San. The military was now heading down a different path, one in which its legitimacy was not guaranteed. Later, Ne Win attempted to blame subordinates for the action, but the damaged was already done.

The Revolutionary Council also wanted to separate religion from politics. Monastic orders that tended to be more conservative and less political won the favor of the new administration. Ne Win wanted to clearly articulate the importance of freedom of religion in order to distance himself from the previous administration under U Nu. The regime was walking a tightrope between alienating the Buddhist majority while at the same time wanting to secure its Buddhist credentials. A process of weeding out false or politically